

COMS 4113 Homeworks

Fall 2026

The homework series, and HW1 in depth

- Deadlines & how HWs factor into your grade
- Difficulty
 - Tips
 - Testing your assignments
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Deadlines & Your Grade

How they count

8 homeworks in total
(excludes hw0)

- Best **6 of 7** used for hw1 through hw4b ... **60%**
- **hw5 is a must** ... **10%**
- Total = **70%** of your final grade

Coursework	Release date	Submission deadline	Time provided
hw0	Tue 09/08	Sun 09/13	5 days(!)
hw1	Sun 09/13	Sun 09/20	1 week
hw2a	Sun 09/20	Sun 10/04	2 weeks
hw2b	Sun 10/04	Sun 10/11	1 week
hw3a	Sun 10/11	Sun 10/25	2 weeks
hw3b	Sun 10/25	Sun 11/08	2 weeks
hw4a	Sun 11/08	Sun 11/22	2 weeks
hw4b	Sun 11/22	Sun 12/06	2 weeks
hw5	Sun 12/06	Sun 12/20	2 weeks



Tips across all homework assignments

- Read the papers and understand the protocol *before* coding
- Print your results frequently when debugging a distributed system
- Start your part B before the deadline of part A
- When designing your solution for part A, keep part B in mind
- Read ahead!
- Get familiar with what the tests expect for each assignment

Testing your assignments



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- Run the unit tests **at least 100 times**, ideally on more than one machine
- The result is **not deterministic** - especially for HW2-HW4 - because of goroutine and thread scheduling
- Passing **once** does **not** mean your code is correct, and it may still fail on our grading machine
- We will **not** add hidden tests cases. Everything you have is all we will run, but many many times
- You may add print statements to the unit tests - just remove them before submitting

A test that passes is one execution that happened to work. **A concurrency bug you did not hit is still in there.** That's why you should run tests many times, perhaps tens of times.

Overview of homeworks

Homework	Project	Related topics
HW1	MapReduce	MapReduce, RPC
HW2	Primary/Backup Key/Value Datastore	Fault tolerance
HW3	Paxos & Key/Value Datastore	Consensus, Paxos, availability
HW4	Sharded Key/Value Datastore	Scalability, Paxos, atomic commitment
HW5	Model Checking the Paxos Protocol	Testing & model checking

Themes across all HWs

Test-driven: the tests are provided

You are not guessing at the specification. The tests ARE the specification, and you can read them before you write a line.

Most API skeletons are provided

- You fill them out
- You can add more logic and functions
- But for all given functions KEEP the function signatures the same

Design, design, design

The coding is rarely the hard part. Deciding what state lives where, and who is allowed to change it, is.

Data structures

- Some are provided
- Some you modify
- Some you write yourself
- Which need a lock, and what invariant it protects, recurs

- Unit tests are used to grade your assignments
- Unit tests in the same homework each have the **same weight**
- Each unit test is run **many times**
- Every time a unit test fails, the score of that unit test is multiplied by **0.9**

#fails	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	25
score	100%	90%	81%	73%	66%	59%	53%	48%	43%	7%

The decay is *gradual*, but it never stops. Half your credit is gone by six failures.

HW1 - MapReduce

Getting used to **RPC** and **Go**, on a simple Map/Reduce implementation.

Part 1 - Map & Reduce

Write the map and reduce functions themselves. One process, no distribution, no failures. This part teaches you the shape of the computation.

Part 2 - Distribute it

A master hands map and reduce jobs out to workers over RPC. Now there is a network, and the interesting questions start.

Part 3 - Handle failures

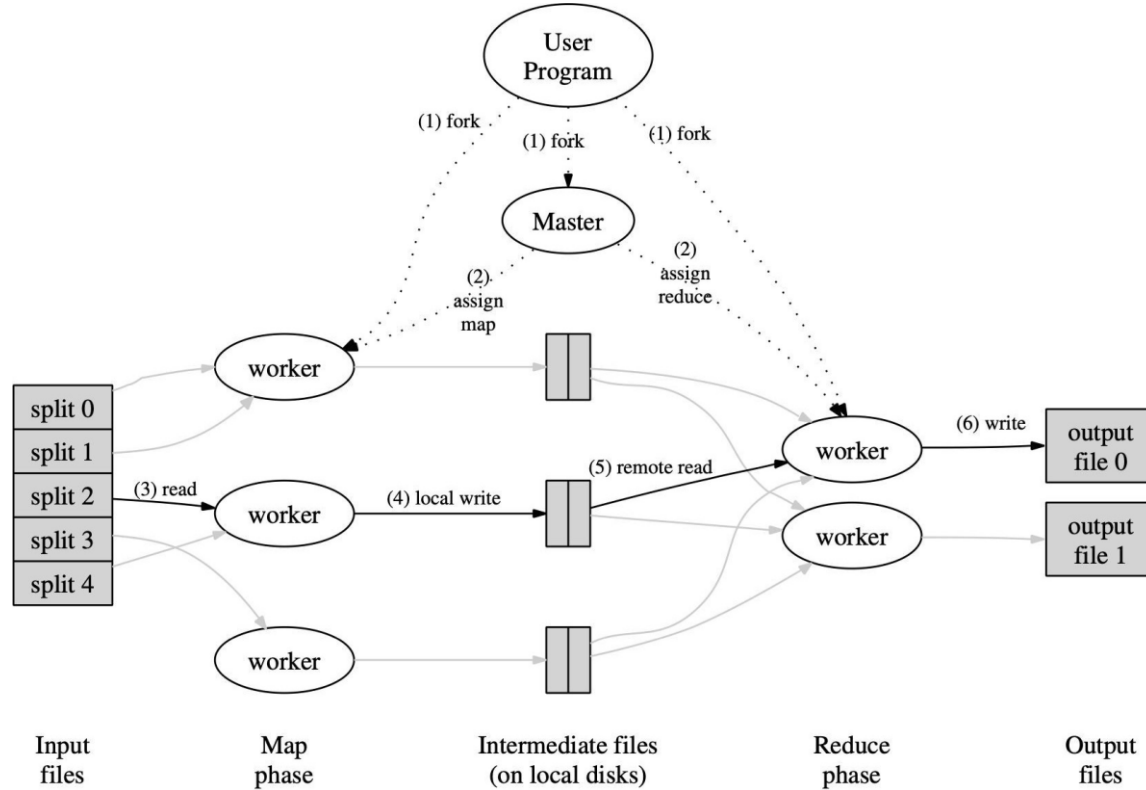
A worker can die mid-job. The work still has to finish. This is the first fault tolerance you write in this course.

Why MapReduce first? Map and reduce tasks are deterministic and side-effect-free, so recovering from a dead worker is just *run it again somewhere else* - no state to reconcile, no agreement needed. Every later assignment loses that luxury.

HW1 - MapReduce



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HW1 - WordCount, Step by Step

Split the input: input-1.txt, input-2.txt, ..., input-m.txt

Map phase

"..., a dog, a cat ..." =>

```
{"a": ["1", "1"], "dog": ["1"], "cat": ["1"], ...}
```

Intermediate files - one per (map task, reduce partition) pair

```
int-file-1-1.txt      {"a": ["1", "1"], "cat": ["1"], ...}
```

```
int-file-1-2.txt      {"dog": ["1"], ...}
```

```
...
```

```
int-file-m-r.txt
```

With **m** splits and **r** partitions there are **m × r** intermediate files.

HW1 - WordCount, Continued

Reduce phase - all values for one key, from every map task

```
{ "a": ["1", "1"], "cat": ["1"], ... },  
{ "a": ["1", "1", "1"], "apple": ["1", "1"]}    =>
```

```
{ "a": "5"}, { "apple": "2"}, { "cat": "1"}, ...
```

Output: output-1.txt, output-2.txt, ..., output-r.txt

Two things to notice. **r output files, not one** - the output is partitioned the same way the intermediate data was. And the counts add across every map task: "a" comes out as **5** because reduce sees every partial list for that key, from all m of them.

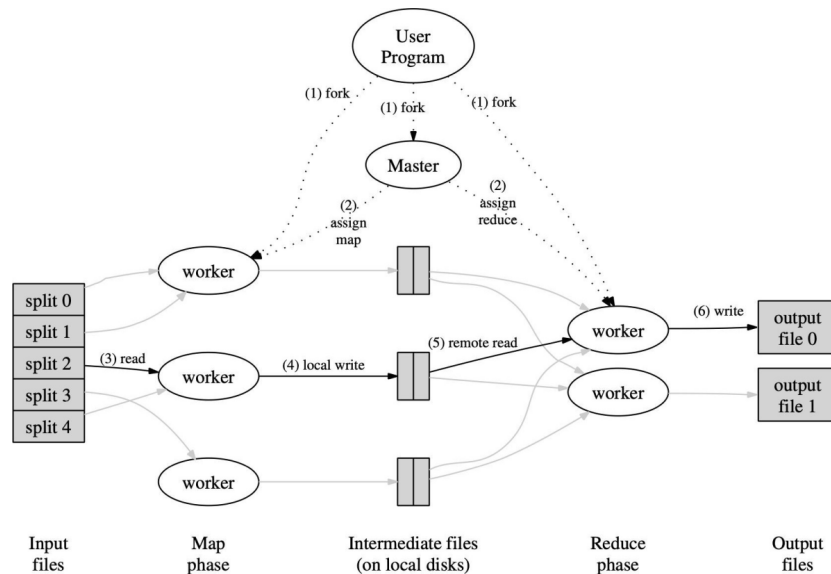
HW1 - The Three Parts

Part 1

- Straightforward implementation
 - A few ways to run this (sequential, etc.)
 - The comments provide some instructions
- Map each word; count the mappings

Part 2 / 3

- Map & Reduce are written for you
- You distribute the workload
 - Write a master that coordinates Map & Reduce jobs between workers
- Account for worker failures



Grading for HW1

Test 1 - 20 points (Part 1)

- `test-wc.sh`, under `src/main`
- **Pass or fail.** If it passes you get all 20; if not, this part scores 0.

Test 2 - 100 points (Part 2/3)

- Follows the grading scheme from the earlier slide
- 50 runs per test, x0.9 per failure

The final grade is **120 points, scaled to 100.**

For example, if you get:

20 points in **Test 1**

70 points in **Test 2**

$(20 + 70) \times 5/6 = \mathbf{75}$

Test 1 is all or nothing. `test-wc.sh` either passes or you lose all 20 points - a sixth of the assignment - on the easiest part of the work. *Run it before you submit.*



Thanks to all prior TAs

Questions?